WORLD WAR II



THE BATTLE OF CAPE MATAPAN

Date March 28–29, 1941
Location Off coast of Greece
Result Allied victory

COMBATANTS

BRITAIN | **ITALY**

COMMANDERS

Sir Andrew Cunningham | **Angelo Iachino**

FORCES

Ships: 1 carrier, 3 battleships, 24 other ships | **Ships:** 1 battleship, 6 heavy cruisers, 19 other ships

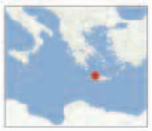
LOSSES

Men: 3
Ships: none | **Men:** c.2,300
Ships: 3 heavy cruisers, 2 destroyers

Ambush at Cape Matapan
HMS *Valiant*, together with her fellow Queen Elizabeth-class battleships *Barham* and *Warspite*, fires her 15-in guns. The three British battleships destroyed two Italian cruisers and two destroyers at Cape Matapan.

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CRETE



Date May 21–June 1, 1941
Forces British: 1 carrier, 4 battleships, 12 cruisers, 32 destroyers; Axis: unknown
Losses British: 3 cruisers and 6 destroyers sunk; Axis: unknown

Location Crete, eastern Mediterranean

On May 20, 1941, German paratroops launched an assault upon Crete, held by British Commonwealth troops. British naval commander Admiral Cunningham was determined to prevent German troop reinforcements arriving by sea from Greece. His principle throughout was that "the Navy must not let the Army down." Since his ships were operating without air cover within range of German land-based aircraft, losses were inevitably heavy. On May 21 a first flotilla of German troop transports was forced to turn back. The next day a larger invasion force was attacked and scattered, but this time Luftwaffe air attacks took their toll—the cruiser *Gloucester* sunk and 723 lives were lost. From May 28, with the land battle on Crete lost, the Royal Navy's task was to evacuate as many troops as possible to Egypt. This was a perilous task. The destroyers *Hereward* and *Imperial* were sunk evacuating troops from Heraklion on May 29. Most troops were taken off from Sphakia in southern Crete. In all some 16,000 soldiers were evacuated. The last Royal Navy ship sunk was the cruiser *Calcutta*, sent from Alexandria to cover the withdrawal, on June 1. The British had lost nine ships, all to aerial attack, and had 15 others damaged. Some 2,000 sailors lost their lives.

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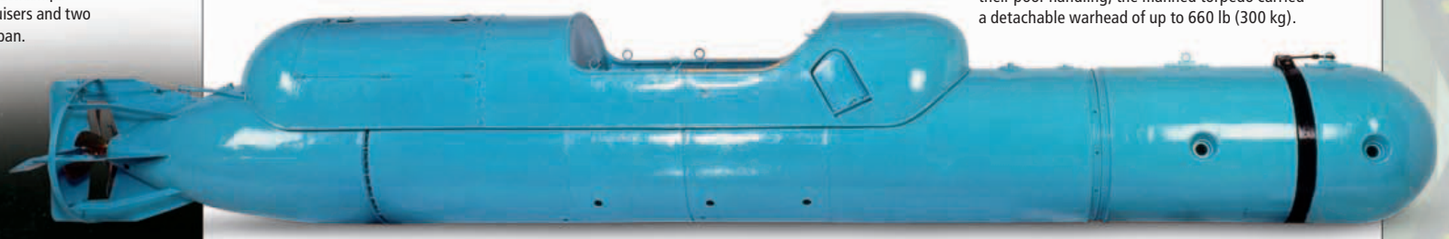
RAID ON ALEXANDRIA



Date December 17–18, 1941
Forces British: unknown; Italians: 1 submarine, 3 midget submarines
Losses Italians: 3 midget submarines; British: 2 battleships, 1 destroyer severely damaged, 1 tanker sunk

Location Alexandria, Egypt

The Italian Regia Marina developed midget submarines known as *Maiali*, for underwater raids on British harbors. On the night of December 17-18, 1941, three *Maiali* were carried to the entrance of Alexandria harbor, home of the British Mediterranean Fleet, by the submarine *Scire*. Released under water, they penetrated the harbor's defenses undetected by following behind a British cruiser, the entry of which required the anti-submarine barrier to be opened. Two of the crews attached their charges to the hulls of the battleships *Valiant* and *Queen Elizabeth*—Admiral Andrew Cunningham's flagship. The third was destined for the absent aircraft carrier *Eagle*, so a large tanker, *Sagona* was targeted instead. The time-delayed charges exploded the next morning. The two battleships were severely damaged, *Queen Elizabeth* settling on the bottom of the shallow harbor. The explosion under the tanker also damaged the destroyer *Jervis*. All of the Italian commandos were taken prisoner. Both of the battleships were eventually returned to action, but the short-term loss to British naval strength in the Mediterranean was serious.



Italian manned torpedo
Nicknamed *maiali* (pigs) by their crews because of their poor handling, the manned torpedo carried a detachable warhead of up to 660 lb (300 kg).

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SECOND SIRTE



Date March 22, 1942
Forces British: 5 cruisers, 18 destroyers, 1 submarine; Italians: 1 battleship, 3 cruisers, 8 destroyers, 1 submarine
Losses British: none; Italians: none

Location Gulf of Sirte, Mediterranean

The First Battle of Sirte, on December 17, 1941, was an inconclusive fight between Italian and British convoy escort forces under Admiral Angelo Iachino and Rear-Admiral Philip Vian. The same commanders clashed at the same location three months later. Vian was escorting four supply ships from Alexandria to Malta, with four light cruisers, an anti-aircraft cruiser, and a bevy of destroyers. The Italian Regia Marina intercepted with a squadron that included the heavy cruisers *Gorizia* and *Trento*, and the battleship *Littorio*. The weather was stormy, with heavy seas. Vian sighted the heavy cruisers and, leaving five destroyers to escort the supply ships, turned the rest of his escort force to confront the enemy. The Italians maneuvered to draw the British toward their battleship, which loomed into sight around 4 p.m. Heavily outgunned, the British laid down a thick smoke screen, from behind which they dodged out intermittently to engage the Italians with their guns and torpedoes. The destroyer *Kingston* was almost torn apart by a hit from *Littorio*'s 15-in armament and *Havock* was so badly damaged she was for a time dead in the water. Most of the British cruisers also took hits. Toward nightfall Admiral Iachino withdrew, and all the British ships were able to escape. The aftermath of the battle was painful for both sides. Two Italian destroyers foundered in a storm returning home; all the British supply ships were sunk by air attack on arrival at Malta.

WEAPONS AND TECHNOLOGY

ENIGMA INTERCEPTS

The Enigma machines used by the German Navy for encoding communications used three (later four) rotors to scramble the messages. They were considered utterly secure because the receiver needed to know the exact settings of the rotors, which changed daily. British codebreakers, however, intermittently managed to decipher these messages, providing advance warning of the movements of Axis warships, supply convoys, and submarines. The Enigma intelligence is credited, among other things, with contributing to victory at Cape Matapan and the defeat of German U-boats in the Atlantic.



Enigma machine
By rotating the cylinders at the rear of the machine, code settings could be changed daily. Viewing windows on the lid showed the encoded letters.